IMMERSION 1 · TOPIC PRESENTATION · DESIGN SCIENCE RESEARCH

Designing a Hybrid Alignment Diagnostic

A design science proposal for bounded delegated agent workflows in India-based B2B service organisations.

Sanjay Gupta · GGU DBA in Emerging Technologies (Generative AI), Cohort 8

BACKGROUND

Existing alignment tools give delegated workflows a starting point

- **Problem:** Managers delegate agent actions; they should verify strategic warrant, but whether records support judgement remains unknown.
- Strategy maps, OKRs, alignment maturity and NIST provide existing assessment resources.
- McKinsey 2026 survey: **40%** of respondents from >US$1bn organisations scale agents; previously **27%**.
- Smaller-organisation respondents: **22%**, unchanged; adoption is context, not local misalignment evidence.

McKinsey & Company, 2026: survey, 1,719 respondents, May–June 2026; Tabassi, 2023.

PRELIMINARY LITERATURE AND DUAL GAP

The gap is warranted assessment against serious existing alternatives

RQ1 · REQUIREMENTS

- Delegation supports evidence rules (Baird & Maruping, 2021).
- Governance already includes alignment (Mäntymäki et al., 2022).
- Research gap: warranted rules and local comparative performance remain unresolved.

RQ2 · REPRESENTATION

- Strategic fit informs relationships (Henderson & Venkatraman, 1993/1999).
- Existing diagnostics are rivals (Diab, 2021; Issa et al., 2026).
- Practitioner gap: actionable judgements from available records remain unconfirmed.

RQ3 · EVALUATION

- FEDS separates evaluation purposes/settings (Venable et al., 2016).
- Behaviour matters beyond ratings (Buçinca et al., 2021).
- Hybrid performance is task-dependent (Vaccaro et al., 2024).

Tabassi, 2023; Murray et al., 2021; Alfaify & Almarzooq, 2025. Close full-text review remains open.

SP → RO → RQ → DP → DATA → TEST

Three sub-problems, three questions, one complete research chain

SUB-PROBLEM	OBJECTIVE	RQ / TYPE	PROPOSITION	DATA	TEST
SP1: evidence rules	RO1: matrix +2m; expert check +5m	RQ1: requirements? Exploratory	DP1: relevance; clarity	12–16 interviews; records; 9 experts	Matrix; ≥8/9 per item, each dimension
SP2: representation	RO2: v1/v2 +5m	RQ2: L1–L4/interfaces? Design	DP2: coverage; fidelity	Versions; links; change log	Feature/test per requirement; ≥90% faithful
SP3: performance	RO3: evaluate +8m	RQ3: versus practice? Comparative	DP3–6: performance; value; use	12+12 cases; 3 workflows; 12–16 users	Precision/recall; yield; SUS; utility

Proposed; t0 = IRB clearance; +m = months after t0. Thresholds: slide 7. Peffers et al., 2007.

RESEARCH LOGIC

Conceptual framework: theory → requirement → feature → evaluation

KERNEL → REQUIREMENT

- Pragmatism: warranted use, inspectable evidence.
- Delegation: rights/actions (Baird & Maruping, 2021).
- REQ3: compare delegated rights with actual actions.

PRINCIPLE → FEATURE

- DPr3: separate intended, authorised and observed states.
- Feature: mandate ⇔ permission ⇔ action evidence.
- L1–L4: provisional representation; include horizontal interfaces.

EVALUATION → REVISION

- DP2: faithful mappings; DP3: controlled performance.
- Failed rules → revision → retest.
- M1: goal/specification mismatch; M1–M6 remain provisional.

Hevner et al., 2004; Henderson & Venkatraman, 1993/1999; Murray et al., 2021; Tabassi, 2023.

DSRM supplies six outputs; FEDS plans two build–evaluate cycles

DEFINE

- 1 Identify problem → problem statement.
- 2 Define objectives → requirements matrix, t0+2 months.
- New interviews; existing strategy and authority records.

CONSTRUCT AND DEMONSTRATE

- 3 Design/develop → v1, revision log, v2, t0+5 months.
- 4 Demonstrate → completed workflow assessments.
- Cycle 1: artificial/formative; expert ratings and controlled tasks.

EVALUATE AND COMMUNICATE

- 5 Evaluate → DP decisions, t0+8 months.
- 6 Communicate → dissertation and principles, t0+9 months.
- Frozen-v2 held-out confirmation; Cycle 2: naturalistic/summative matched comparison.

Peffers et al., 2007; Venable et al., 2016. New interviews/ratings/tasks; existing authorised records.

PRE-SET DECISIONS · NO RESULTS YET

Acceptance criteria are separate, proposed and allowed to fail

CONTENT AND REPRESENTATION

- DP1: if ≥8/9 rate relevance/clarity separately → content criterion met.
- DP2: feature/test per requirement; ≥90% faithful mappings → criterion met.
- Otherwise unmet; compromised evidence → inconclusive.

PERFORMANCE AND FIELD VALUE

- DP3: held-out precision/recall each ≥80% → controlled criterion met.
- DP4: added warranted findings in ≥2/3 workflows → criterion met.
- Same evidence/time; controlled performance is not field sensitivity.

USABILITY AND UTILITY

- DP5: if SUS ≥70 → usability criterion met.
- DP6: if ≥80% rate prioritisation 4–5 → utility criterion met.
- Satisfaction cannot rescue failed performance.

Proposed local thresholds; no results. Venable et al., 2016; Buçinca et al., 2021.

PROPOSED SCOPE · ETHICS · FEASIBILITY

The workflow is bounded; access and permission remain gates

CHOSEN SCOPE

- 3 workflows; 1–2 India-based B2B service sites.
- Workflow participants: business owners, leads, operators and governance specialists.
- No prevalence, model internals or legal certification.

PEOPLE AND PERMISSIONS

- 12–16 interviews/users; 9 experts; separate 3-person reference team.
- Independent evaluators; relevant expertise; commitments unconfirmed.
- IRB first; organisation, participant and record-use permissions separate.

LIMITS → MITIGATIONS

- Small groups → descriptive, contextual conclusions.
- Withheld records → unknown; failed access → reviewed scope change.
- Unread rivals → obtain full texts before fixing novelty.

Proposed groups; access pending; no data yet. Tabassi, 2023; Hevner et al., 2004.

ILLUSTRATIVE — NO STUDY RESULTS

A leader inspects evidence, preserves unknowns and chooses an action

SAME ILLUSTRATIVE EVIDENCE

- Enterprise: reliable service; unit: timely resolution under approved rules.
- Mandate: approve exceptions; agent objective: resolve requests.
- Both methods: identical mandate, permission, action and approval records.

EVIDENCE → DECISION

- Documented authorised trade-off → no mismatch on this criterion.
- Approval evidence missing → unknown; request evidence.
- Sufficient evidence of action outside authority → warranted M3 finding.

DECISION → ACTION

- M3: record evidence and escalate; preserve disputed interpretations.
- M4: identify who can monitor and remedy.
- Existing review may agree; no incremental benefit established.

Illustrative — no study results. Baird & Maruping, 2021; Santoni de Sio & Mecacci, 2021.

PROPOSED CONTRIBUTION · FEEDBACK SOUGHT

A proposed instrument and conditional design knowledge

PRACTICE

- Hybrid Alignment Diagnostic: instrument, evidence register, interpretation guide.
- Managers inspect warranted findings and choose responsible next steps.

KNOWLEDGE

- Conditional design principles; successful and failed tests.
- No evaluation results yet; transfer requires another bounded test.

QUESTIONS FOR THE PANEL

- Is this bounded comparative DSR scope appropriate?
- What evidence and error costs justify the proposed thresholds?

Proposed outputs, not achieved benefits. Hevner et al., 2004; Peffers et al., 2007; Venable et al., 2016.